# 16

# UNDER THE KNIFE

It started in Amsterdam, of all places. It was just another net session before the Videocon Cup tri-series involving Australia and Pakistan towards the end of August 2004. Ajit Agarkar was bowling to me and bowled a short one, which I fended off with one hand. I instantly realized I had done something to my elbow. Andrew Leipus, our physio, didn't like the look of it at all. It turns out he was right to be concerned.

It was an unfortunate situation because my in-laws had travelled to Amsterdam with their friends from London to see me play and here I was nursing what was later diagnosed as tennis elbow. To complicate matters, I also had a virus and for a good three days couldn't set foot outside my hotel room. I was desperate to get back in shape as quickly as possible because the ICC Champions Trophy in England started in September and in October Australia were due to arrive in India for a four-Test series.

I did all I could to get the elbow injury treated. An expert in Amsterdam tried to help it by manipulating my wrist. He suspected the elbow was being overloaded because of stiffness in my wrist, but unfortunately those painful sessions didn't help much. Then I tried shockwave therapy, which involved a machine that looked like a hairdryer being placed on my elbow. The feeling reminded me of blowing up a balloon and at one point I thought my elbow was going to burst under the pressure.

Anjali was about to join me in England and I called her to say she should bring a video camera across. I remember telling her that she would never see me in more physical pain, and we videoed one of the